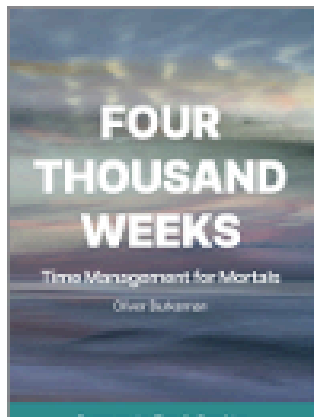




FOUR THOUSAND WEEKS

Time Management for Mortals

Oliver Burkeman



The Big “So What”

If you live to 80 years old, you only have 4,000 weeks on Earth. Rather than cram more into your life, how can you live each day more meaningfully? This book helps you to answer this question, so you can make peace with your limitations, focus on what truly matters, and live a more purposeful and fulfilling life.

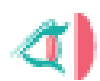


Introduction



Today, we're surrounded by strategies, tools, and resources to help boost our productivity. Yet, the more efficient we become, the more we cram into each day, only to end up feeling more rushed, more impatient, and unfulfilled.

- We often feel guilty for not accomplishing all that we expect of ourselves. We get frustrated by time-wasters, without pausing to consider what all the frantic rush is for.
- Burkeman, formerly a productivity geek, used to believe that he'd get a peace of mind when he finally got on top of his tasks. However, that day never arrived, and he only felt increasingly stressed and unhappy.



This book offers a new perspective on productivity and time management. Burkeman suggests that the solution is to stop trying to manage time as a resource. Instead, accept that you have a finite amount of time on Earth, and consciously choose what to do with it.

KEY QUOTES

"Time management, broadly defined, should be everyone's chief concern. Arguably, time management is all life is."

"The world is bursting with wonder, and yet it's the rare productivity guru who seems to have considered the possibility that the ultimate point of all our frenetic doing might be to experience more of that wonder."



Shifting from Productivity to Purposeful Living



Rethink Your Relationship With Time

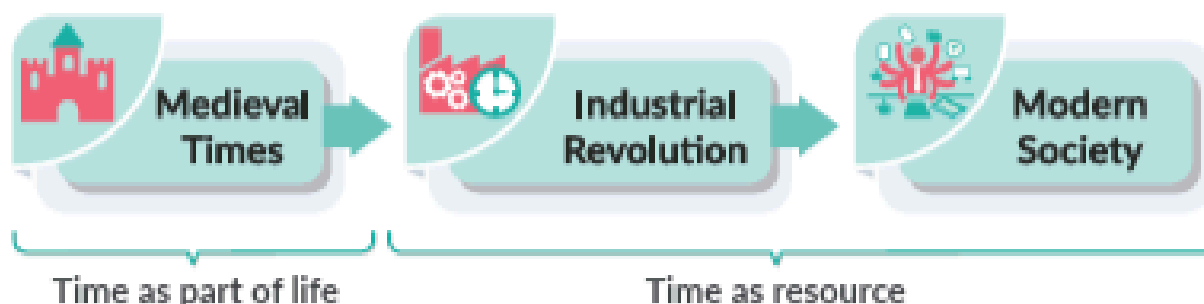


A lifespan of 80 years translates to merely 4,000 weeks, which means your time is limited. Yet, the problem isn't with our finite time, but how we think about it.



Historically, people used to think of time differently.

- Before mechanical clocks, people viewed time as the essence of life, or the river in which life flowed. They “measured” time using the day’s natural rhythm (e.g. sunrise and sunset), and accepted that things took as long as they needed to take. A medieval farmer, for example, worked in tune with nature’s schedule, not a clock. He wouldn’t try to compress a year’s harvest into 1 month, or get a month’s worth of milk in 1 day.
- With the mechanical clock and Industrial Revolution, our relationship with time was fundamentally changed. Laborers were paid by the hour, factories operated during fixed hours, and a new demarcation appeared between work and leisure. We could literally see the minutes and hours slipping by, and started to treat time as a resource to be used and traded. We try to “save” time, feel guilty if we “waste” time, and seek to work ever harder, faster, and smarter.
- Our perspective on time is also shaped by external forces. For example, Capitalism views everything (including time and people) as tools for profit. If you’re a lawyer who bills your clients by the hour, you may start to see each hour with family or friends as an opportunity cost, and thus an indulgence you can’t afford.



KEY QUOTES

“Before, time was just the medium in which life unfolded... Afterwards...time became a thing that you used.”

“[Time] stops being the merely the water in which you swim and turns into something you feel you need to dominate or control.”



Beware the Efficiency Trap



Research shows that people are feeling busier than ever, and this sense of overwhelm occurs at every economic level. Those further down the economic ladder might feel overstretched as they work 2-3 jobs to pay the bills, while those further up the ladder might feel overloaded due to higher mortgages, job demands or social obligations.



Ironically, we try to solve our busyness by doing more. Instead of cutting back, we pack more into our days, believing efficiency can somehow help us to do it all. We use productivity hacks (e.g. "batch" our work or use prioritized to-do lists) to work faster.

- However, the more you fit into your life, the more you have to do. The goal-post keeps shifting. This is summed up by Parkinson's Law, which says that "Work expands so as to fill the time available for its completion."
- Burkeman calls this the "efficiency trap". For example, the sooner you reply to emails, the sooner others reply, which means more emails in your inbox. And, if people know you reply quickly to emails, they're more likely to write to you. As a result, the faster you respond, the more emails you get. The more you try to control time, the more you become controlled by it.



"Existential overwhelm" is the feeling that there's always more to do or explore than possible.

- In modern societies, secular changes have led to fewer people believing in an afterlife. As a result, people feel pressured to make the most of this life—the only life they have. We try to pack our lives with experiences, yet we feel dissatisfied because there's always *more* to be experienced.

KEY QUOTES

"You have too much to do, so you try to fit more in, but the ironic result is that you end up with more to do."

"The trouble with attempting to master your time, it turns out, is that time ends up mastering you."

"The problem with trying to make time for everything that feels important—or just for enough of what feels important—is that you definitely never will."

- There's an infinite number of leisure activities you can do, and it's impossible to experience all of them in your lifetime. The Internet further amplifies what you're missing out on.



As you cram more into your life, the quality of your activities also drops.

- If you think that you can somehow get everything done, you're more likely to accept a task/request without stopping to consider if it's worth doing, or what you must sacrifice to do it.
- When you're busy and overwhelmed, you're also more likely to opt for convenient solutions instead of valuable ones. You might message a friend instead of meeting up in person, or grab some fast-food instead of cooking a meal.



To overcome anxiety and overwhelm, the best solution is to accept reality. There are infinite things you could do, but you're limited by finite time, energy, attention, and resources. Rather than try to tick off every item on an endless to-do list, consciously choose how to spend your finite time meaningfully.



Live in the Present, Not in the Future



Viewing time as an instrument makes us treat each moment as a means to an end.

- We often put our lives on hold, thinking "After this, I can relax" or "Once I get that promotion, I'll find love." We treat every task and event as a stepping stone to something else.
- Burkeman's perspective shifted with fatherhood. He wanted to savor his son's early years, yet found most parenting advice focused on preparing children for the future. When we treat childhood as a training ground for adulthood, we rob it childhood of its intrinsic value.



When we live mentally in the future, we miss out on the present.

- Burkeman observes how tourists at a museum often take photos and videos of the art pieces instead of enjoying them there and then. We use mindfulness practices to try and be present, missing the fact that we are *already* present in the

KEY QUOTES

"Convenience...makes things easy, but without regard to whether easiness is truly what's most valuable in any given context."

"I'm aware of no other time management technique that's half as effective as just facing the way things truly are."

"Stop postponing the 'real meaning' of your existence into the future, and throw yourself into life now."

"[To live] more fully in the moment starts from noticing that you are, in fact, always already living in the moment anyway, whether you like it or not."

moment. Many rich people are unhappy despite their wealth, because they see the current moment as a stepping stone to a happier future.

- You don't necessarily need more money and status to feel happier, and you don't need to keep doing more to prove your inherent worth. Learn to appreciate the present while keeping an eye on the future. Find contentment in the simple pleasures already available to you.



Embrace Your Finitude



Philosopher Martin Heidegger argued that humans don't have a finite amount of time; we are a finite amount of time. He used the term "finitude" to describe how our limited time fundamentally defines us.

- Here's an uncomfortable truth: our time on Earth is not an entitlement. We are all living on borrowed time. If you died tomorrow, there's nothing you can do about the time you "lost", because you never owned it in the first place. You don't actually *have* time; you merely expect it, and there's no guarantee you'll have more time beyond the present moment.
- People who've had a close brush with death often start to see time differently. You don't need a tragedy to shift your perspective on time and mortality. The next time you feel annoyed at waiting in queue, or feel frustrated that someone is late, pause to appreciate the fact that you're alive right now. Instead of feeling cheated of time, cherish the present moment as it might be all you have.



Every decision you make closes off other alternatives, and propels you down a certain path. This is happening whether you're aware of it or not. If you're not choosing your paths intentionally, then you're just stumbling through life blindly.

- Accept the trade-offs in every choice. When you choose 1 important thing, it means giving up lesser priorities and saying "no" to other opportunities. Make peace with that.

KEY QUOTES

"Usually there'll be no way to know, in the moment itself, that you're doing it for the last time."

*"We cannot get anything out of life. There is no outside where we could take this thing to... The life of this moment has no outside."
—Jay Jennifer Matthews*

"Once you stop believing that it might somehow be possible to avoid hard choices about time, it gets easier to make better ones."



Dispel the Illusion of Control



We want to see time as a separate tool or resource, because it gives us the illusion of control.

- In reality, you cannot control time. The Hofstadter's Law says that tasks always take longer than planned. You might think you have 5 hours to complete a project, but issues crop up. You expect to meet with a friend next year, but she passes away before then.
- You also cannot predict the future. If you look back at the events that led to where you are today, you'll find that many were beyond your control. For example, your parents might have migrated to a new country while you were young, or you might have met your spouse at a random party. You survived those chance encounters in the past, and will probably survive whatever life throws at you in the future.



While planning is useful, remember that plans don't give you the power to control the future. You can't prevent bad things from happening, nor force things to go according to your expectations. Instead of resisting your circumstances, allow things to happen at their own time and just do the best with what life offers.



Reclaim Your Focus



Your attention is limited, just like your time. What you focus on defines your reality, e.g. if you constantly follow news about crimes and disasters, you'll see the world as a dangerous place. In the end, your life will be the sum of what you pay attention to.

- Social media isn't really "free" because the tech companies are selling your attention to advertisers, and using data tracking and psychological tactics to keep you hooked. Our digital devices often distract us from other important matters—we spend hours on our devices daily, and our minds tend to linger on trivial online interactions even when we're offline.

KEY QUOTES

"You can never be truly certain about the future. And so your reach will always exceed your grasp."

"All a plan is—all it could ever possibly be—is a present-moment statement of intent... The future, of course, is under no obligation to comply."

"What you pay attention to will define, for you, what reality is."

"The distracted person isn't really choosing at all. Their attention has been commandeered by forces that don't have their highest interests at heart."



Burkeman argues that we choose to get distracted to avoid painful issues or decisions.

- For example, when it's time for an important task, you might suddenly feel the urge to check your emails or surf the internet. That's because taking action means facing up to your realities and limitations, instead of just dreaming about ideal outcomes.
- Fixes like digital detoxes typically won't work in the long-term, as they don't address the root causes of the discomfort, and you'll just turn to other distractions. The best way to overcome a distraction is to accept and pay attention to the underlying discomfort. When Steve Young trained as a Buddhist monk, he had to pour freezing water over himself daily. In the process, he learned that trying to distract himself from the cold only worsened the agony. The best way to ease his discomfort was actually to focus on it. This training helping him to drastically improve his concentration.



Cultivate Patience



Burkeman suggests that we're getting more impatient as a society. In a traffic jam, people start honking even though it doesn't change anything. We stop the microwave oven before the time is up, just to save a few seconds.

- Our addiction to speed, much like an addiction to alcohol, is often a form of emotional avoidance. We feel as if we must move faster to be happy, when it only leaves us feeling more anxious and restless.



To break this cycle, stop trying to move faster and allow things to take their time. Cultivate patience to enjoy better results and satisfaction.

- In face of a problem, don't rush to adopt the first solution that comes to mind. If you can sit with the unease of not having an immediate answer, a better solution will often emerge.
- Adopt 3 principles of patience:
 - (i) *Embrace challenges* as a part of human existence. Recognize that a problem-free existence would be meaningless.

KEY QUOTES

"The paradoxical reward for accepting reality's constraints is that they no longer feel so constraining."

"As the world gets faster and faster, we come to believe that our happiness, or our financial survival, depends on our being able to work and move and make things happen at superhuman speed."

"If you're willing to endure the discomfort of not knowing, a solution will often present itself."

- (ii) Choose *incremental progress* over immediate completion. Stop work each day when the time is up, even if you still have excess energy. This builds patience for long-term success.
- (iii) Give yourself *time to develop mastery and originality*. When you first learn something new, it's normal to imitate others. Your unique style tends to emerge as you grow over time.



Enjoy Rest and Leisure For Their Own Sakes



In the past, ancient philosophers like Aristotle viewed leisure as the goal in life. Work was just the means to enable more leisure time. Religious traditions like the Sabbath (a day for rest and observance) are also built on the belief that whatever work done by week's end is sufficient.



By contrast, modern societies now treat leisure as the means to an end.

- We feel compelled to justify leisure as a way to boost productivity, improve ourselves, create memories, or to build the foundation for some future payoff.
- We feel guilty for being idle or lazy, a concept that sociologists call "idleness aversion." We try to pack every day of the week, with shops staying open daily and digital devices keeping us connected all the time.
- In "Midlife", Kieran Setiya highlights the difference between atelic and telic activities.
 - (i) Atelic activities are valuable in themselves and there's no need to "complete" them. For example, you can enjoy walking or listening to music for their own sakes. Telic activities are done to achieve a specific outcome.
 - (ii) Midlife crisis often kicks in when we start to realize our mortality, the futility of chasing future goals, and start to focus more on present experiences.

KEY QUOTES

"The presence of problems in your life...isn't an impediment to a meaningful existence but the very substance of one."

"Enjoying leisure for its own sake—which you might have assumed was the whole point of leisure—comes to feel as though it's somehow not quite enough."

"Results aren't everything. Indeed, they'd better not be, because results always come later—and later is always too late."



Burkeman urges us to enjoy rest and leisure for their own sakes, without guilt. Pursue hobbies that bring you joy and satisfaction, even if you're mediocre at them and there's no financial or social benefits to be gained.



Adopt Intentional Neglect



Everyone procrastinates. "Bad" procrastination stems from being paralyzed by your limitations. This could come from:

- Perfectionist expectations: You hold back because you think you lack what it takes to achieve your dream outcome; and/or
- Indecision: You're stuck between choices, e.g. you can't decide between various career options, or you want to leave an abusive relationship yet secretly hope for things to change. You fail to commit—until the ship has sailed and you no longer have to decide.



"Good" procrastination comes from accepting that you can't do and have everything you want. You make sound decisions to (i) do what matters most, and (ii) procrastinate on lesser priorities.

- Burkeman shares 3 principles for intentional neglect:
 - (i) *Pay yourself first*. In personal finance, this means saving before paying your bills. Similarly, prioritize important goals (e.g. developing a relationship or learning a new skill) before other tasks. Don't wait.
 - (ii) It can feel overwhelming to have too many tasks or projects running concurrently, and you can't get anything meaningful done if you abandon a project once it gets hard or boring. The solution is to *limit your work-in-progress*: (a) finish an old project before starting a new one, and (b) break big projects down to bite-sized chunks that you can finish.
 - (iii) *Avoid the lure of secondary priorities*, as they're the most likely to distract you from your core priorities. List down your top 25 priorities, then focus only on the top 5 and deliberately avoid the rest.

KEY QUOTES

"In order to most fully inhabit the only life you ever get, you have to refrain from using every spare hour for personal growth. From this perspective, idleness isn't merely forgivable; it's practically an obligation."

"The real measure of any time management technique is whether or not it helps you neglect the right things."



Commitment gives you freedom. Research shows that when people commit to something, they appreciate it more than those who can still change their minds.

- Political theorist Robert Goodin argues that you must commit to something to attain excellence or fulfillment. For example, you can't be the best musician in the world if you don't devote your time and focus to music.
- Commitment is also essential for relationships. A romantic relationship can't be fulfilling if you break things off every few years in hope of finding a better partner. Ultimately, there's no perfect person who can meet all your conflicting needs. Someone who's stable and predictable is also unlikely to be a regular source of adventure and excitement.
- Making a commitment frees you from the need to keep choosing, so you can direct your focus in more meaningful ways.



Choose Shared Experiences Over Full Control



Many people love the idea of having full control over their lives—to have the freedom to do whatever they want, whenever they want, and without answering to anyone.



Burkeman argues that time should be shared, not hoarded.

- Sacrificing some personal freedom can lead to greater fulfillment if you get to spend the time with loved ones. For example, digital nomads have the freedom to travel, yet many feel lonely because their lifestyle makes it hard to form deep relationships.
- Time is a network good. Similar to mobile phones and social media accounts, time is more valuable when it's shared with others. Many activities, such as socializing or going on dates, require others' participation. In 2013, Terry Hartig found that Swedes were happier when they took time off work, and happiness levels were even higher when they had shared time off. He suggested that what people needed wasn't more control over their personal schedules, but better "social regulation of time".

KEY QUOTES

"We'll do almost anything to avoid burning our bridges, to keep alive the fantasy of a future unconstrained by limitation, yet having burned them, we're generally pleased that we did so."

"When you can no longer turn back, anxiety falls away, because now there's only one direction to travel: forward into the consequences of your choice."

"Freedom, sometimes, is to be found not in achieving greater sovereignty over your own schedule but in allowing yourself to be constrained by the rhythms of community."

"The value of time comes not from the sheer quantity you have, but from whether you're in sync with the people you care about most something intangible."

- Human beings are naturally inclined toward synchronicity: we tend to sync our steps when walking with someone, and Roman soldiers could march longer when they moved in unison. When you feel like a part of something bigger than yourself, it can be more fulfilling than having complete control over your personal time or schedule.



Find Freedom in Your Cosmic Insignificance



All of us want to believe that our lives mean something, and we feel a sense of grandiosity when we talk about "what matters most" in life. Yet, in the grand scheme of things, what you do doesn't matter at all.

- Human civilization (about 6,000 years old) is a blip in the universe's timeline, and each of us a miniscule part of history. At a cosmic level, no individual can make a dent in the Universe—even famous names like Mozart, Einstein, or Marie Curie.



Realizing our cosmic insignificance can be liberating, because (i) it puts our problems and daily struggles into perspective, and (ii) frees us from illusions of grandeur.

- Instead of holding yourself to unattainable standards, focus on meaningful activities within your reach. Ask yourself: How can I make the most of my time now, assuming this moment is all I have? This may include the things you're already doing but didn't seem grand enough. For instance, the Covid pandemic brought pain and disruption, but also reminded us of simple pleasures like gardening, cooking, and family time. It forced us to reevaluate our daily lives and routines, such as long commutes to work or under-appreciation of essential workers.



Let Go Of The Illusion of Time Mastery



We want to master time, stay in control and feel like our lives matter. Yet, time mastery is an illusion: No matter how good you get at time management or your specialization, you can't

KEY QUOTES

"Time just feels realer – more intense, more vivid, more filled with meaning – when you're synchronized well with others."

"Because now is all you ever get."

handle everything thrown at you. And none of our lives can truly matter in the cosmic timeline. Embrace life's finitude, free yourself to live fully in the moment, and focus on what truly matters to you and those around you.



Use these 5 questions to guide yourself:

- What necessary discomforts are you avoiding? Embrace risks and challenges that help you to grow, rather than hide behind the illusion of safety or control.
- Are you holding yourself to unattainable standards? Consider what you'd do differently if you stopped chasing after an impossible to-do/bucket list.
- Have you accepted yourself as you are? Or are you striving to be someone else (and living by others' standards)?
- In which areas of life are you still holding back because you don't feel prepared? Free yourself by taking action regardless.
- Most meaningful activities like care-giving or community-building cannot be measured by concrete outcomes. How would you spend your time differently if you didn't care about end-results?



Ultimately, we must each find our own path without knowing what the "right" course of action is. As Carl Jung advised, just do what feels necessary and trust that life will unfold as it should.

KEY QUOTES

"Let your impossible standards crash to the ground. Then pick a few meaningful tasks from the rubble and get started on them today."

"The undodgeable reality of a finite human life is that you are going to have to choose."



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This book is written in a conversational style, packed with personal anecdotes, examples, and research references to help us reflect on finitude and rethink our relationship with time. For more details, please visit www.oliverburkeman.com.